▶ RAJASTHAN

A LEASE RENEWAL AT CM'S OFFICE

Ambitious rivals crowd the Jaipur palace, but BJP is inclined to favour Sharma's continuation

By **Rohit Parihar**

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SEAL OF TRUST Bhajan Lal Sharma greets BJP chief J.P. Nadda during a party camp in Narmada, May 6

Takeaways

- **An imminent reshuffle of Rajasthan cabinet renews speculation on CM's post**
- **Nadda's public backing of Sharma sets record straight even as rival power centres mushroom within party**

THERE WAS A PIECE OF PUBLIC performance, there were private conversations—and plenty of whispers off-stage. Happily for CM Bhajan Lal Sharma, the important facts all seem in virtuous alignment. When BJP president J.P. Nadda chose Jaipur to mark the 300th birth anniversary of Ahilyabai Holkar, it wasn't just about honouring a Maratha queen. Sharma, 18 months young in his tenure, had never managed to get himself off the receiving end of pointed social media gossip. Credible or not, the buzz about a change of guard was always in the air, like a beast with a life of its own.

Spurring it is the imminence of a reshuffle in a cabinet strikingly full of freshers. With veterans getting restive and rival power centres coalescing, the recipe also has that extra lemon twist this time: the idea that Sharma's exit could be timed with Nadda's departure as BJP chief. The fuzzy chronology of the latter has prolonged the suspense, not ended it. All together, the perceived crisis of authority seemed serious enough to warrant a rebuttal.

On stage, Nadda wasted no time on platitudes. "Making Bhajan Lal the CM is not the issue," he declared, at the May 31 event. "It's about having a dedicated soldier of the ideology... working day and night under Modi's leadership." As Sharma listened from the dais with a half-smile, Nadda cut deeper. "When there's a difference between day and night, you ought to like the day," he said. A jab, some would say, at the Vasundhara Raje camp.

SCOTCHING SPECULATION

Behind closed doors, Nadda is believed to have reviewed ministerial performance, preparatory to an anticipated shake-up. Will Sharma seize the moment to stamp his authority on things? Will he have to accommodate dissenters? Will he become a casualty of high-stakes party dynamics? At least on the last, Nadda has implied it's too early to turn the page. Leader of Opposition Tikaram Jully allowed himself a dig, saying Nadda's remarks confirm that Sharma's position is iffy.

Among his ambitious seniors, agriculture minister Kirori Lal Meena resumed office in April, 10 months after a dramatic resignation that was never accepted. Rebellious as ever, he upstaged Nadda's visit by storming half-a-dozen factories accused of producing spurious fertilisers—a not-so-subtle critique of government functioning. Then there's Rajyavardhan Rathore, industries and sports minister, and now a quiet dissenter.

All this discounts Sharma's own capabilities, as an approachable man whose free access extends from common MLAs to Union ministers. On May 25, he presented the resolution on Operation Sindoor at an NDA CM's conclave. There are those who say he's the BJP's best bet in 2028. ■